

Enactment # 18

Chickasaw Tribal Legislature

November 21, 1986

Wilson Seawright authored the following bill; which was approved by the Special Committee on the Tribal Newspaper, and was referred to the Legislative Committee.

A BILL

To establish uniform guidelines and procedures governing the administration and publication of the Chickasaw newspaper.

Be it enacted by the Tribal Legislature of the Chickasaw Nation assembled, that this act may be cited as "The Chickasaw Newspaper Act".

SECTION 2: THE LEGISLATURE FINDS THAT--

(1) Tribal funds are used to publish the Chickasaw Newspaper, and these funds must be utilized efficiently without waste or misuse.

(2) Providing true and accurate information to Chickasaw citizens is of utmost importance.

(3) The current Tribal Newspaper is commonly known as the Chickasaw Times.

(4) There exists a need to establish formal, uniform guidelines and procedures governing the administration and publication of the Chickasaw Times.

(5) There exists a need to establish a formal job description for the editor of the Chickasaw Times.

SECTION 3: FOR THE PURPOSE OF THIS ACT--

(1) Chickasaw Nation shall mean the Tribe of Indians located within the boundaries set forth in the Constitution of the Chickasaw Nation being duly recognized by the Secretary of Interior of the United States of America, as a self governing, independent sovereign government.

(2) Constitution shall mean the Constitution of the Chickasaw Nation as originally adopted by the people on August 27, 1983.

(3) Chickasaw Citizen shall mean any Chickasaw Indian by blood, whose name appears on the final rolls of the Chickasaw Nation approved pursuant to Section 2 of the Act of April 26, 1906 (34 Stat. 137) and their lineal descendants.

(4) Tribal Legislature shall mean the Legislative Department of the Chickasaw Nation as set forth in Article VI of the Constitution of the Chickasaw Nation adopted August 27, 1983.

(5) Chickasaw Times shall mean the current official newspaper of the Chickasaw Nation.

(6) Editor shall mean the current editor of the Chickasaw Times who, has independent authority to publish the Tribal newspaper.

SECTION 4: The basis for authority of this Act is Article VII, Section 4 of the Constitution of the Chickasaw Nation, wherein the Tribal Legislature is granted the power and authority to enact rules and regulations pertaining to the Chickasaw Nation in accordance with the Constitution. The Chickasaw Tribal Legislature with the adoption of this act hereby:

Establishes the attached Editorial Policy for the Chickasaw Times and the Job Discription for Editor of the Chickasaw Times.

Editorial Policies of
The Chickasaw Nation

I. Purpose:

The purpose of these Editorial policies, is to establish uniform guidelines and procedures governing administration and publication of the Chickasaw Times (hereinafter referred to as the "Times").

Established editorial policies allows the editor, employees, readers and all interested parties to fully understand the philosophy and function of the Times.

Tribal funds are used to publish the Times, and these funds must be utilized efficiently without waste or misuse.

II. General Philosophy:

The Times shall be fair, impartial and inform the Chickasaw public of the tribal goals, operations, procedures, services and emphasizing the accomplishments and opinions of all Chickasaw citizens. No person or collection of persons shall be allowed to dominate the Times in any form or fashion.

III. Legal Basis:

Article IV, Section 4 of the Constitution of the Chickasaw Nations states:

"Every citizens shall be at liberty to speak, write or publish his opinions on any subject, being responsible for the abuse of that privilege, and no law shall ever be passed curtailing the liberty of speech, or of the press."

Article VII, Section 4 of the Constitution states:

"The Tribal Legislature shall enact rules and regulations pertaining to the Chickasaw Nation."

The "Times" staff shall uphold the provisions of the Constitution.

IV. General Provisions:

1. The Times shall be a monthly publications, with an additional special election issue.

2. The Times shall be mailed free of charge to all registered Chickasaw voters, public schools and public libraries within the Chickasaw Nation, colleges and universities within Oklahoma, weekly and daily newspapers within the Chickasaw Nation plus the Daily Oklahoman, Tulsa Tribune and Tulsa World, and the other four civilized tribes.
3. Articles and other items submitted to the Times should, if notifying the readers of an upcoming event, provide enough lead time for the event to be covered in an upcoming issue.
4. The established deadline of the first day of the month allows the paper to be prepared with adequate time for the printer to complete his tasks and copies can be mailed by the 15th of each month.
5. Articles, letters to the editor and other items submitted to the "Times", from Chickasaw citizens should be accepted and printed, providing the article is based on fact, is presented in good taste and adheres to the following basic criteria:
 - A. Material should convey the quality of being actual, such as an actual occurrence proven by witnesses.
 - B. Opinions should be based on sincerity in action, character, judgement, or ideas that are true or accepted as true.
 - C. Articles which are controversial in nature may require written evidence to prove the material is based on fact.
 - D. Use of unfriendly or bitter words, used expressly with the intention to inflict damage should be avoided.
 - E. Articles may be submitted to inform the readers about an event, idea, product or person with consideration of the laws on slander and libel.
6. Any article which cannot be published will be returned to the presenter, with an explanation, detailing the reasons why said article could not be published.
7. A minimum of two pages, for each of the Executive, Legislative and Judicial Departments (a total of six pages) in each issue should be reserved, to be used at the discretion of the department.
8. Political announcements and campaign statements shall be restricted to the special election edition. The lone exception would be the initial announcement of any candidate who wishes to make an early announcement as information to the voters. (This shall be limited to ten column inches).

9. The "Times" on a regular basis, shall include feature articles on original enrollees, outstanding businessmen and women, professionals, honor students, outstanding athletes, high school and college graduates, profiles on Chickasaw employees and historical data as well as contemporary information on Chickasaws from all geographic areas.
10. The "Times" on an annual basis shall publish, in its January issue, an evaluation questionnaire to be voluntarily returned by readers. The results of this evaluation shall be used as a reference to determine the future direction of the "Times" before budget approval, by the Legislature.
11. The Editor of the "Times" shall be allowed to work independently, but in cooperation with all entities of the Chickasaw Nation.

V. Procedure to Amend Editorial Policy:

The Editorial Policy as written will remain in effect until such time that the Chickasaw Tribal Legislature adopts or amends new or current policy. Such changes can be accomplished, by a citizen or official of the Chickasaw Nation, presenting written proposals to the Tribal Legislature for their purview and action.

Job Description
For
Editor of Chickasaw Times

Functional purpose:

Working independently, without domination from the Executive, Legislative or Judicial branches, the editor will research, write, edit, prepare graphic materials and layouts and publish the Chickasaw Times newspaper.

The editor will adhere to the editorial policies of the Chickasaw Times to insure that Chickasaw citizens are informed of the tribal goals, operations, procedures, services and emphasizing the accomplishments and opinions of all Chickasaw citizens.

Examples of work performed:

Collects information and material of current interest, from throughout the Chickasaw Nation through conferences, correspondence and research.

Drafts, composes and edits material of various types to appeal to current popular taste or of interest to the Chickasaw public.

Reviews and edits material presented by citizens for publication. Editing shall not remove the intent of any article.

Prepares explanatory response to citizens, whose articles cannot be published.

May serve as photographer with responsibility for writing related captions and/or feature stories relating to photographs.

Confers with Chickasaw representatives, who are involved with civic, community and other special interest groups to secure and furnish information to promote the Chickasaw Nation.

Researches and prepares special reports as assigned.
Maintains library and files of source materials.
Performs related work as required and assigned.

Knowledge and skills:

Knowledge of journalistic writing; of accepted styles for materials released to the print media; of media sources; of common printing technology; of photographic principles and techniques; of English language such as spelling, vocabulary, grammar, sentence and paragraph construction; of editing and proofreading.

Skill in preparing written material and in eliciting correct information in a well-planned interview; and in working with government, civic officials and the public; in gathering and organizing pertinent data.

Education and experience:

Prefer completion of the curriculum requirements for a baccalaureate degree in journalism, photo journalism, English, speech, communications or public relations

OR

College level understanding of journalism, English communications or public relations, with moderate experience (three years) in public relations, news writing or news media operations.

Special requirements:

Should have a current C.D.I.B. card from a recognized Indian tribe, preferably a Chickasaw with insight on the beliefs and interests of the Chickasaw public.

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The Legislature is in agreement that the position of the editor should be advertised so the process of hiring an editor may begin.